

Dhāraṇī of the Noble Avalokiteśvara

Āryāvalokiteśvaradhāraṇī · Toh 716 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་སྐྱུ་རས་གཟགིས་དབང་ཡུ་ག་གི་ཟུངས།

Toh 716 in the Kangyur is a short dhāraṇī text known in Tibetan as the dhāraṇī for memorizing, addressed to the noble Avalokiteśvara — the great bodhisattva of compassion known in Sanskrit as Avalokiteśvara and in Tibetan as Spyan ras gzigs dbang phyug. It belongs to the dhāraṇī genre of canonical literature, presenting a brief mantra ritual in which a practitioner forms a maṇḍala before Avalokiteśvara, recites the mantra one hundred and eight times over a thumb-sized portion of butter, and consumes it to gain extraordinary powers of memorization, progressively retaining thousands of verses over the course of seven days. The text is placed among the dhāraṇī collections of the Kangyur and is representative of the practical, ritual-oriented scriptures within that corpus that invoke the power of bodhisattvas to confer specific worldly and spiritual benefits.

Here ends the dhāraṇī for memorizing. Homage to the Three Jewels. Homage to the great bodhisattva, the bodhisattva of great compassion, the noble Avalokiteśvara, Lord of What Is Seen.

Tadyathā: Oṃ munikante muniprabhasvare svāhā.

Having formed a maṇḍala before the Blessed One, the noble Avalokiteśvara, one should take a thumb-sized portion of clean butter, recite this mantra one hundred and eight times, and then eat it. On the very first day, one will memorize as much as if one had read one thousand verses. On the day that three days have elapsed, one will memorize three thousand verses. On the day that seven days have elapsed, one will retain whatever one has heard. Here ends the dhāraṇī for memorizing three thousand verses.

Translator's Notes

- The term "མཁའ་ལྷན་པ་" most likely refers to clarified butter or a pure fatty substance used in ritual contexts; "clean butter" is a reasonable rendering. The phrase "མཁའ་ལྷན་པ་ལྷན་པ་" literally means "the first day," indicating the day of the practice itself. The mantra syllables are transliterated as they appear, preserving the standard Sanskrit phonetic rendering. The closing colophon appears twice in slightly different forms, marking both the end of this section and the end of the full dhāraṇī text for memorization.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.